

The Greengrass Greengage Affair

Tier	Tier 2
Party Level	4 PCs at Level 5 (advance to 6 at the Ashaba House debrief) — Loric absent (Lily not at the table)
Duration	~3.5–4 hours of play
Setting	The Shrine antechamber → Northern Traverse → Shadowdale (Ashaba House, the village green, the Old Skull Inn, the Living Wood edge, the riverbank)
Hook From	Session 003 — <i>The Half-Mask Shrine</i> (Khelziir and Zeldrazz dead; anchor still standing)
Plot chosen	Plot A — Greengrass with The Antlered Herald as the Crash antagonist



Adventure Summary

Session 004 has two halves. The **first** is paperwork — the leftover business from Session 003. The party stands over Khelziir's body in the Shrine and has to **decide what to do with the portal anchor**, walk back to Shadowdale, and take their pay from Lady Ulphor at the Ashaba House. They hit **Level 6** at debrief.

The **second half** is the Greengrass festival. Spring has cracked open on the Ashaba and Shadowdale is already half-decorated when the party walks in. Lady Ulphor "asks" the party to stay on as honored guests of the Ashaba House for the next day's events. Each PC gets a dedicated festival station with a real skill challenge — archery on the riverbank, a bardic showcase, an arcane stall, the Dragonchess Open, the druid Greening, and (placeholder for Nema) a footrace.

At dusk, when Lady Ulphor lifts the firebrand to light the bonfire, **the Antlered Herald** rides out of the Living Wood on a stag the size of a draft horse. He has come to deliver the unnamed fey lord's invitation — and his arrival is mistaken for an attack. Combat starts because someone draws a weapon before he speaks. He doesn't want to kill anyone, but he will not be embarrassed; he wants to see the surface party who killed a drow priest on his lord's borders, take a measure of them, deliver the standard's message, and leave.

The session ends with the Herald vanishing into the Living Wood, Sela Wyndmere stepping between him and the party at the treeline, and the fey-court arc cracked open.

PART ONE — Cleaning Up

~45–60 minutes of play. This is fixed regardless of which festival plot was chosen.

Scene 1 — The Anchor Decision

Setup

The Shrine. Khelziir is dead on the basalt altar. Zeldrazz is dead at his feet. The portal anchor — a polished basalt disc roughly two feet across, inscribed with half-finished glyphs in silver and shadowstuff — is still standing, still humming, still very much **on**. The ritual countdown is stopped (Khelziir is no longer alive to drive it) but the anchor itself didn't switch off when he died. It's waiting.

*The drum is gone from the air. Khelziir's blood is pooling under the altar in a slow black ring, and his half-mask lies face-up beside him, the silver still warm. The anchor at the center of the chamber is humming the way a tuning fork hums after the strike — softer, fading, but not yet quiet. The glyphs on its rim still pulse, once every three breaths. **It is waiting for someone to finish.***

The Choices

The party has four options. Quillip's earlier intel (Session 003 Scene 3) and Yinu's Arcana now together give them enough to choose cleanly.

Choice	What It Does	Cost / Note
Smash	Destroy the anchor. Definitive. AC 12, HP 40, vuln. bludgeoning.	Loud, simple. The Vhaeraunians find a shattered basalt disc — they know who did it. Brynn and Lady Ulphor read it as a strong message.
Steal	Pry the anchor out of its mount and carry it home. Yinu/Nalith can stabilize it for transport with Arcana DC 14.	The anchor goes to Orvyn for study (and quietly to the Harpers). Lady Ulphor's bonus shifts to +200 gp .
Feed (<i>Harper option</i>)	Leave the anchor running but slip a Harper listening-glyph into the matrix. Yinu Arcana DC 17 (with expertise so feasible).	Highest reward, slowest payoff. Orvyn pays +300 gp and starts treating the party as Harper-adjacent. Opens a future listening session when something speaks through it.
Withdraw	Walk away. Leave the anchor as found.	The Vhaeraunians repair it. Retaliation clock accelerates. Use only if the party is exhausted and wants the session to move.

Yinu Spots the Fey-Wrong

Before the party commits, Nalith (Druidic-sensitive, Circle of Dreams) feels a *second* hum under the first — a fey resonance the drow didn't put there. The anchor's outer rim has been inscribed by drow hands, but its **core** is older. Someone fey carved the inner ring a long time ago and the drow never noticed. *This is the first plant for the Crash.* Don't explain it; let the players notice or not.

NPC Returns

- **Loric T. (Lily)** — **Not at the table this session.** In fiction, Loric stayed at the Old Skull Inn rather than coming up to the Shrine. He is not with the party for any beat in this adventure. Easy retcon back in next session — he was just at the inn the whole time.

- **Nema (Lilli)** — She was already at the cold camp, was on overwatch outside, and steps in now. She missed the bosses but she's here for cleanup.

DM Notes

- **Don't push a choice.** All four are valid. If the party debates, Quillip's intel said the listening-glyph is "the most useful, the most dangerous, the most fey of the three" — that's enough hint for kids who want a hint.
- Yinu loots Khelziir's silver half-mask in S3. It's still on her. Note this for Plot A's Yinu station.
- The journal Kto/Fox lifted from the antechamber bedrolls is Zeldrazz's demoted-captain's log — surface it now if the party didn't read it last session.

Scene 2 — The Walk Back

The Trek

Half a day overland down the southern face of the Old Skull. No combat. Use the walk to:

- **Hand out loot.** Khelziir's silver half-mask (Yinu has it), 60 gp of Khelziir's pouch coin, his prayer chains (sellable to Orvyn for ~80 gp combined), Zeldrazz's poison vials (×2 drow poison), the antechamber crossbows. Standard divvy.
- **Surface Brynn's letter.** Kto is still carrying it. If she finally tells the party, run that beat here. If she doesn't, **Brynn surfaces it himself the next day at the festival** — see *Brynn at the Old Skull* in Scene 5. He approaches Kto privately and asks whether his letter ever reached its intended recipient. That's the on-ramp; Kto chooses what to do with it.
- **Let the kids breathe.** Banter. Marching order. Fiorn doing impressions of Khelziir's death gurgle.

The First Greengrass Sign

About an hour out of Shadowdale, the party crests a ridge and sees the village below. There are **flower-crowns hanging from every fence**, a **bonfire-pile already stacked** on the river-stones below the Old Skull's southern flank, and **river-runners poling barges across the Ashaba for the first time since the thaw**. It's the night before Greengrass. Spring has officially cracked open.

You come down the south face of the Old Skull and the village is full of flowers. The fences are hung with them. The bonfire on the river-stones is stacked head-high and someone has already tied the first ribbon. Two barges are crossing the Ashaba going the wrong way — eastward, toward Battledale — for the first time since you've been here. It is the eve of Greengrass.

DM Notes

- Don't slow down. This is a montage beat, not a scene.
- If anyone asks what Greengrass is: spring festival, first night of Mirtul, flowers and bonfires, the river crossings open, the fey walk openly. Sela will be running the Greening at the wood's edge tomorrow.

Scene 3 — The Ashaba House Debrief

Setup

Lady Ulphor's solar. Late afternoon. Brynn Ashford is at her right hand with the ledger. Orvyn Tal arrives midway through (he closed the bookshop early). Captain Helm is **not** here — he's at the green, helping his militia put up the procession poles, and Lady Ulphor will tell you that with a small smile.

Tone

Warmer than Session 2's debrief. Lady Ulphor has paid Captain Helm's stitches twice now to cover the party's mistakes; she has also paid them for two closed sites and what looks like a third. She is starting to think of these five children as *hers*. Brynn is sharper — he caught Kto's eye when she shifted the letter in her belt-pouch on the walk in.

The Beats

- **Who reports first?** Whoever the party picks. Brynn wants the technical write-up (anchor disposition, drow strength, Quillip). Orvyn wants the *meaning* (was the priest a fanatic or a contractor? Who paid him?). Lady Ulphor wants the **count of bodies and the count of secrets**. Let the kids decide the order.
- **The Anchor.** Whatever choice the party made in Scene 1 — Smash, Steal, Feed, or Withdraw — pay out the appropriate consequences. Orvyn lights up at Steal or Feed. Lady Ulphor relaxes visibly at Smash.
- **Pay.** 600 gp baseline (150 gp / PC across the 4 present). Bonuses:
- **The Festival Invitation.** Lady Ulphor's last note in the debrief: she is hosting Greengrass tomorrow and would be deeply pleased if her honored guests would stay on as her honored guests. *"You will not be charged for the Ashaba House while you are mine."* This is not a request. The kids are now stuck in Shadowdale for the festival. Good.
- **Brynn pulls Kto aside.** As the party files out, Brynn touches Kto's elbow — only Kto's — and says, quietly enough that nobody else hears: *"I am at the bookshop on Thursday afternoons."* That's the whole conversation. He's letting her keep the letter on her own time. Move on.

Level Up — Milestone: Level 6

All five PCs hit Level 6 at the end of the debrief. Hand out the level-up sheets at the table. **Encourage the kids to make Level 6 choices on the spot** (Fighter gets an ASI/feat, Rogue gets Subclass feature, Wizard/Sorcerer/Druid get 3rd-level spells filled and a new subclass feature, and so on). If a kid wants to think, give them the night-of-Greengrass time to decide — they don't have to commit until the festival opens.

Bring printed Level 6 reference sheets for each PC. The class features they pick up shape the festival stations — Fiorn's Steady Aim, Yinu's 3rd-level spells, Nalith's Circle of Dreams 6th-level feature, and Kto's ASI/feat all matter for the Crash.

What This Locks In

- Party paid. Lady Ulphor's debt to the table goes from 1 to 0.
- Brynn knows Kto knows.
- Yinu has a Harper marker (only if Feed was chosen).
- The party is in Shadowdale for the next 24 hours.

PART TWO — The Greengrass Greengage Affair

~2–2.5 hours of play. Festival, then crash.

Scene 4 — The Opening Procession

Setup

Mid-morning, Greengrass day. The Twilight Tower bell rings the procession in. The party is wearing flower-crowns Lady Ulphor pressed on them last night (Fiorn's is the largest, ostentatiously). The procession winds from the Tower down to the Ashaba's south bank where Lady Ulphor will officiate the bonfire at dusk.

Read-Aloud — Set the Stage

The Old Skull dome is the backdrop today, gray granite over the green of the village. The procession moves slow, the way the Dales do everything slow — flower crowns on every head, a flute somewhere up front, Captain Helm walking in dress greens with his sword on the wrong hip on purpose. Lady Ulphor is at the head. Sela Wyndmere is at the back, walking with the druids of the Living Wood. Brynn Ashford is standing in front of the Old Skull Inn with a slate and a pile of dragonchess boards, and Orvyn Tal is at a bookstall pretending to read.

The stations open at noon. You may attend whichever calls you.

Stations and Hosts (announced in fiction)

- **The Riverbank Archery Range** — judged by **Captain Helm** with Rellan Tessar competing.
- **The Bardic Showcase** — under the Twilight Tower banner. Headliner: **Halbren Vass**, smug touring half-elf.
- **The Arcane Wonders Stall** — hosted by **Orvyn Tal**.
- **The Greening of the Beasts** — at the edge of the Living Wood. Co-led by **Sela Wyndmere**.
- **(Placeholder) The Festival Footrace** — south bank of the Ashaba. *(For Nema until her sheet is filed.)*

*The Dragonchess Open is **not running as a PC station** with Loric absent. Brynn is still at the Old Skull all afternoon running an open bracket in fiction — see Brynn at the Old Skull below for how the Mistedale Council intel still lands.*

DM Notes — Running the Montage

- Cut between stations like a film montage. Don't keep one PC's player waiting more than ~5 minutes between turns.
- Each station is a **three-check skill challenge** with escalating DCs (13 / 15 / 17). Success ladder is the same at every station:

Successes	Result
3 of 3 — Gold Ribbon	Prize + Heroic Inspiration + a personal NPC scene
2 of 3 — Silver Ribbon	Prize
1 of 3 — Bronze Ribbon	A personal NPC scene
0 of 3	Good-natured loss. The kid still gets a line. No penalty.

- After the last station resolves, give a five-minute break — the bonfire scene is next.

Scene 5 — The Stations

Station A — Riverbank Archery Range (Kto)

Host: Captain Corwick Helm, judging.

Co-competitor: Rellan Tessar, back on his feet and shooting in the same heat.

Setup: Three floral-bobber targets drift in the Ashaba current under the Old Skull wind. Crowds on the south bank.

#	Check	DC	Notes
1	Standing shot vs. anchored target	Attack vs. AC 13	Kto's Longbow +9 with Archery — should hit on most rolls.
2	Wind-read	Wisdom (Perception) DC 15	Kto's +5; competitive. Failure → the next shot is at disadvantage.
3	Moving shot vs. river-bobber	Attack vs. AC 17	Champion's Improved Critical (19–20) makes the sweep plausible.

Gold Ribbon scene: Captain Helm walks down to the water with Kto, says "I am glad I was wrong about him" — and Kto knows he means Rellan, and also doesn't. He extends his hand. **This is the public closure of the S2 Helm rift.** Mark it.

Bronze Ribbon scene: Rellan claps her on the shoulder and says he owes her three arrows for the cliffside. They split a meat pie.

Station B — Bardic Showcase (Fiorn)

Host: Halbren Vass — smug, touring half-elf headliner. *Recurring rival, roster flag.*

Judges: Lady Ulphor and Captain Helm at the judges' table.

Setup: A raised platform under the Twilight Tower banner. Fiorn drew the closing slot (Halbren made sure).

#	Check	DC	Notes
1	Opening number	Performance DC 13	Fiorn's +9 expertise — almost automatic.
2	Crowd-work through Halbren's heckling	Deception DC 15	Fiorn's +9 expertise. Halbren is whispering to the judges; Fiorn has to keep the room.
3	The closing	Performance DC 17	Use Musician feat's Encouraging Song — grants Heroic Inspiration to 3 allies after their next rest. Fox the player loves this.

Gold Ribbon scene: Halbren — for one honest second — looks impressed. Then the mask slides back on and he asks where Fiorn is touring next. *He's recruiting.* Fiorn can take the bait or not.

Bronze Ribbon scene: Halbren wins on votes but Lady Ulphor leans over the judges' table afterward and tells Fiorn quietly that her vote went to him. That's the prize.

Station C — Orvyn's "Wonders of Spring" Arcane Stall (Yinu)

Host: Orvyn Tal, quietly judging.

Setup: Three mystery items donated by villagers, identified live for the crowd.

#	Check	DC	The Item	Notes
1	A fey-touched primrose	Arcana DC 13	Yinu's +11 expertise.	Real answer: a primrose that grew through a Feywild seam. Harmless.
2	A river stone with a faint inscription	Investigation DC 15	Yinu's +8.	Plant. It is a <i>partial Lolthite signal-stone</i> — half of a paired comm device. The other half is in the Underdark. Foreshadowing the wider drow war.
3	A vial of "spring tonic" sold by an outlander stranger	Arcana or Alchemist's Supplies DC 17	Yinu's +11/+? — should hit with expertise.	Plant. It is a <i>Vhaeraunian numbing draught</i> . Whoever sold it is on the green right now. The signal stone is the bait; the draught is the receipt.

Gold Ribbon scene: Orvyn invites Yinu to the bookshop tomorrow afternoon. He says he has "something the Harpers gave me to give to someone like you" — and then catches himself and changes the subject. *Harper recruitment starts here.* Mark it. (If Feed was chosen at the anchor, this lands twice as hard.)

Bronze Ribbon scene: Orvyn quietly slips Yinu the river stone afterward with a "you should keep that" and no explanation.

*The signal stone and the numbing draught are both **plants** for the campaign's drow arc. They don't matter for tonight's Crash (the Herald is fey, not drow). But put them on the table so the kids feel the foreshadowing land later, when the Vhaeraunian retaliation hits in S5–6.*

Brynn at the Old Skull (no dedicated PC station — Loric absent)

Host: Brynn Ashford, running an open dragonchess bracket in the back room of the Old Skull Inn all afternoon — six boards, fourteen villagers, sleeves of summer ale.

No skill challenge. The Dragonchess Open is shelved as a PC station while Loric is away. Any PC who passes through the inn can sit in for a casual game — narrate the result freely.

The Mistledale Council intel still needs to land. Brynn delivers it **directly to Kto** at a quiet moment between her archery heats. He pulls her aside and asks plainly whether the letter he handed her in Session 002 ever reached its intended recipient. Whatever she says, he drops the line himself:

"There's a vote in Mistledale next month. If our anchor was found in their granite instead of ours, the vote tips the other way. You understand?"

Then: "Tell whoever needs to know." He returns to his board. The letter and the Council intel both belong to Kto now — and to the party once she chooses to share.

If Kto already surfaced the letter on the walk back (Scene 2), Brynn instead nods once, says "Then you know what I'm about to tell you," and gives her the Council line plainly with the rest of the party present.

Station E — The Greening of the Beasts (Nalith)

Host: Sela Wyndmere, assisting in the open. **Quillip Burr-and-Whistle**, invisibly watching.

Setup: Living Wood's edge. Canon Greengrass druid observance — flower offerings, blessings of spring animals, a small altar of stacked river-stone.

#	Check	DC	Notes
1	Prepare the blessing posy	Herbalism Kit DC 13	Nalith's Herbalism prof + WIS.
2	Call the animals with a wood instrument	Performance DC 15	Musician feat (Birdpipes/Flute) — strong.
3	Settle a skittish doe in front of the crowd	Animal Handling DC 17	Nalith's +6 — needs a roll.

Gold Ribbon scene: Quillip drops a single dried hawthorn berry at Nalith's feet — visible only to Nalith, who is Druidic-attuned. **This is the plant for the Crash.** The berry is from a hawthorn that doesn't grow in the Living Wood. It grows in the *unnamed fey lord's* domain. Nalith doesn't know that yet. Quillip is warning her. Sela also sees the berry land and goes very still for half a second before she covers it with her foot. *Nalith should notice the cover.*

Bronze Ribbon scene: Sela gives Nalith a small carved-wood badger figurine "from a friend." Margrim Bristle says hello later.

*Whether the berry lands depends on Gold Ribbon. If Nalith doesn't get Gold, **drop the berry anyway** at the end of her station — Quillip likes her. The plant matters; the ribbon doesn't.*

Station F — Festival Footrace (Nema — placeholder)

Setup: Along the Ashaba's south bank. Three legs.

#	Check	DC	Notes
1	The sprint start	Dexterity (Athletics) DC 13	Default — replace once sheet is filed.
2	The middle mile	Constitution save DC 15	Default.
3	The river-stones at the finish	Dexterity (Acrobatics) DC 17	Default.

Gold Ribbon scene: Nema's place. Use this as Nema's **in-fiction introduction to the village** — a public moment. Lady Ulphor pins her ribbon personally.

Bronze Ribbon scene: Nema gets a hand from Rellan at the finish line. Easy friendship beat.

*Do **not** lock the activity until Lilli files Nema's sheet in campaign/party.md. If her sheet arrives before the session and she has, say, a strong CHA stat — swap the footrace for a Singing Contest at the bonfire, or merge her into the bardic showcase as the opener. Nothing downstream depends on this station.*

Scene 6 — The Bonfire

Setup

Dusk. The procession reforms at the river-stones. Lady Ulphor stands on the lifted dais with the firebrand in hand. The party is at the front, ribbons pinned. Captain Helm is on her left, Sela on her right. Brynn is at the side with the rest of the village.

Beats

- **Ribbon ceremony** (~5 min) — read out who won what. Hand out Heroic Inspiration to every Gold Ribbon PC.
- **Lady Ulphor's speech** — one sentence: *"To the first night of Mirtul. To the river running again. To the children who keep my Dale."* Toast the party publicly.
- **A false moment of safety.** Ulphor raises the firebrand toward the bonfire.

Lady Ulphor lifts the brand. The flame catches the wind off the Ashaba and bends sideways once, beautifully. The crowd holds its breath the way crowds do.
Behind her — somewhere out past the river-stones, somewhere at the edge of the Living Wood — a stag steps out of the trees. It is the size of a draft horse. Its antlers are crowned with white blossom. And there is a man riding it.

Initiative is not yet rolled. Cut here for the next scene.

Scene 7 — The Crash: The Antlered Herald

Full combat statblocks, round-by-round priorities, and tactical map are in the-greengrass-greengage-2-combat-tracker.md.
Print-and-keep tactical at-the-table cheat sheet is in the-greengrass-greengage-4-dm-quick-ref.md.

Setup

The Antlered Herald, **Lorindar Greenmantle**, rides out of the Living Wood on his stag **Erith-of-the-First-Snow**. Two **sprite outriders** circle high above on fey-touched owls. He raises a long-staff topped with the unnamed fey lord's standard — a white branch crowned in iron antler, hung with three ribbons of green, white, and bone.

He has come to deliver his lord's invitation.

"Honored guests of the Lady of the Ashaba — and you five who walked into our borders and walked out again — I am Lorindar Greenmantle, Herald of the Bright Court Beneath, and my lord has marked you. He sends greeting on this night of his choosing. He asks—"
And here he sees the standard catch the firelight, and he sees one of you see it, and he smiles, because he thinks you understand.

The Trigger

Sela Wyndmere wears a courier ribbon on her belt — bone-and-green stitched in a knot only the unnamed fey lord's couriers carry. **Fiorn (Passive Perception 12) or Yinu (Passive Perception 15) will recognize the standard's ribbons as the same as the courier-knot on Sela's belt** if they're looking at the standard at all.

- **If a PC names it aloud** — *"Sela's ribbon!"* or similar — Sela goes ash-white and freezes. The kids' guess will be: *the lord who's been using Sela without her consent has just shown up.*

- **If Quillip is on the scene** (she is, invisibly, watching Nalith) — she will appear at Nalith's shoulder and whisper *"He is not here to fight you, but the standard is asking, and he will not be embarrassed."*
- **A weapon comes out before words finish.** Whichever PC moves first — Kto's bow, Fiorn's crossbow, Yinu's Fire Bolt — *that* is the trigger. Initiative on the next breath.

*Do **not** railroad the party into starting the fight. If they hold their hands, the Herald finishes his sentence ("...for an audience at the next full moon, on neutral ground, the hawthorn-cleft of his choosing") and then turns to leave. **Then** Sela calls his name aloud — "Lorindar, you swore not to ask" — and **she** is the one who triggers the fight by stepping between him and the party. The Herald is still the antagonist; Sela is still the trigger. The kids just get a different scene first.*

*If the party holds AND Sela holds, the Herald nods once, the stag turns, and the party gets the audience invitation **without** the combat. This is the "perfect ending" — vanishingly rare, but allow it. Mark the audience for a future session.*

Combat Shape (full detail in file 2)

- **1 named antagonist** — Lorindar Greenmantle, the Antlered Herald (CR 5 fey)
- **2 mooks** — Sprite Outriders on fey-touched owls (CR 1 each)
- **~3 rounds.** Combat is *not* about killing the Herald. He **escapes** when bloodied OR at end of Round 3, whichever comes first.
- **Scripted exit:** Misty Step (at-will) onto the stag's back, the stag bolts into the Living Wood, the sprites peel off into the trees. Sela steps between him and the party at the treeline and the party doesn't pursue.
- **XP target: Hard-leaning for 4×L6** (raw 2,200 → ~3,300 adjusted; Medium ~2,800, Hard ~3,600). Same scripted exit at R3/bloodied — let Sela trigger early if a kid drops below 20% HP.
- **Civilian protection:** Captain Helm + militia + Rellan + Sela form a screen. Civilians are **behind the militia line**. PCs don't choose between damage and rescue.

Loose Ends Cracked Open by the Crash

- **The unnamed fey lord** is now named (sort of — "the Bright Court Beneath," the lord's title still TBD).
- **Sela Wyndmere's "consultations"** have a face now. The party will have questions.
- **Quillip's silence** about Sela's fey lord in S3 — explained. She knew him. She was warning Nalith with the hawthorn berry.
- **The audience invitation** — at the next full moon, hawthorn-cleft of his choosing. **Mark for S5 or S6.**

Scene 8 — The Aftermath (the last 15 minutes of play)

Setup

The Herald is gone. The stag's hoofprints in the river-mud are filling with white blossom. The sprites are nowhere. The bonfire is still standing — Lady Ulphor never dropped the brand. The crowd is murmuring and starting to leave.

Beats

- **Sela Wyndmere walks up.** She is shaking. She tells the party, plainly and without preamble: *"He has been using me. I knew. I didn't know how to say it."* This is the **opening of the Sela arc** — her courier work, the messages she doesn't read, the lord she's been carrying for.

- **Lady Ulphor crosses to the party.** Quiet. *"You will tell me everything tomorrow. Tonight we light the fire."* And she does. The flame catches. The crowd cheers anyway.
- **Brynn Ashford pulls Kto aside again.** Same line: *"Thursday afternoons."*
- **Orvyn Tal pulls Yinu aside.** *"That stall was not an accident. The river stone, the tonic, this. The Harpers have been waiting for you for two years."*
- **Halbren Vass tips his hat to Fiorn from the crowd, then is gone.** Mark for S5+.
- **Quillip appears at Nalith's elbow.** *"I'll be at the hawthorn at quarter-moon. Bring four friends. Not five."* She gives Nalith a real wink. (This is the **chained Plot B hook** for a future session.)

End of Session

Cut on Lady Ulphor's bonfire roaring up against the dusk and the party standing in front of it with ribbons pinned, level 6, and a fey lord on their dance card.

Loot & Rewards Summary

Currency

- **Baseline (debrief):** 600 gp (150 gp / PC across the 4 present — Loric absent)
- **Anchor bonus:** +100 / +200 / +300 / 0 (Smash / Steal / Feed / Withdraw)
- **Festival ribbons:** 25 gp / Gold Ribbon (Lady Ulphor's purse), 10 gp / Silver, 0 / Bronze

Magic Items / Boons

- **Encouraging Song** post-Bardic Showcase (Fiorn Musician feat) — Heroic Inspiration to 3 allies after rest. Standard feat use; no new item.
- **Khelziir's silver half-mask** (Yinu's loot from S3) — keep on Yinu. Plot-significant later. Treat as a sentimental item for now.
- **River-stone signal fragment** (Yinu, if she earned Station C Bronze+) — Lolthite paired comm half. Useless on its own. Plot bait.
- **Vial of "spring tonic"** (Yinu, if she identified it) — 2 doses of Vhaeraunian numbing draught. Mechanically: as *poison, basic (Drow)* but on a CON save DC 13, target is poisoned for 1 hr instead of unconscious.
- **Dried hawthorn berry** (Nalith) — fey gift. Plant in soil at quarter-moon and it grows into a hawthorn that always blooms two weeks early. Cosmetic. Lovely.
- **Harper primer book** (Yinu, if she earned Station C Gold OR if Feed was chosen) — *Cypher and Glyph-Sign in the Northern Sword Coast*. No price tag. Subtle Harper recruitment.

XP / Milestone

- **Level 6** at debrief. Milestone, not XP. (*See party.md once edited to reflect L6.*)

DM Additions Flagged for Roster / World Canonization

Drafted but not yet entered in the campaign bible. Add to `campaign/roster.md` after the session runs:

- **Lorindar Greenmantle, the Antlered Herald** — fey, CR 5, outrider of the Bright Court Beneath. Recurring villain-or-ally pending the audience. Statblock in file 2.
- **Erith-of-the-First-Snow** — Lorindar's stag mount, draft-horse-sized, antlers crowned in white blossom. Not statted as a separate combatant; treated as Lorindar's mount.
- **The Bright Court Beneath** — the unnamed fey lord's court title. Lord himself still unnamed. Drop into `factions.md` under §8 (Fey of the Living Wood) as a sub-entry.
- **Halbren Vass** — half-elf touring minstrel, Fiorn's recurring rival. Bardic Showcase.
- **Margrim Bristle** — awakened badger, Sela's rehab patient. Cameo prize for Nalith. Optional in this session.

*After this session Sela Wyndmere's faction status shifts from "warm secondary contact" to "**actively asking the party for help.**" Update `factions.md` §8 and `roster.md`.*

Combat Tracker — The Crash at the Bonfire

Encounter 1 — The Crash at the Bonfire

End of Scene 6 · Medium (raw 2,200 XP → ~3,300 adjusted) · 3-round scripted escape

Summary

Location	River-stones of the Ashaba, south bank below the Old Skull's southern flank. Open ground; village green at PC backs; the Living Wood ~120 ft east across the stones.
Light	Dusk. Torchlit firebreak on the PC side; deep gloaming under the treeline.
Terrain	River-stones are difficult terrain for Medium creatures (Lorindar's stag ignores). Open village green. ~120 ft engagement range from treeline to firebreak. Sprites enter 80 ft up on fey-touched giant owls.
Antagonists	1× Lorindar Greenmantle, the Antlered Herald (CR 5 fey) + 2× Sprite Outrider (CR 1 fey, owl-mounted).
Party	4 PCs at Level 6 (Loric absent — Lily not at the table).
XP	Raw 2,200 → ×1.5 multi-foe → ~3,300 adjusted (Medium threshold for 4×L6 is ~2,800; Hard ~3,600). Hard-leaning with one fewer caster — same scripted exit (R3/bloodied) still applies; let Sela trigger early if a kid drops below 20% HP.
Duration	3 rounds maximum. Lorindar escapes at end of R3 or when bloodied — whichever first.
Goal (PCs)	Draw blood. Remember the face. Stopping the escape is not the goal and is not expected.
Goal (Lorindar)	Recon. Provocation. Deliver the audience invitation even if the party will not listen. Leave without killing a child.
Civilians	Behind Captain Helm's militia line. Not in danger — Helm's people screen them. PCs do not have to triage.

Round Strip & Initiative

Round: 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10

NPC initiative is pre-rolled (DEX-averaged). PCs roll live and write into the blank rows.

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
22	Sprite Outrider 1	15	22 □□□□□	Owl-mounted, 80 ft fly, hovering 80 ft up
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
18	Lorindar Greenmantle	16	85 □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□	Mounted on Erith. Bloodied @ 42□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□

Init	Combatant	AC	HP	Notes
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____
15	Sprite Outrider 2	15	22 □□□□□	Owl-mounted, 80 ft fly, hovering 80 ft up
—	_____	—	_____	_____
—	_____	—	_____	_____

Conditions: Bln · Chr · Deaf · Frt · Grp · Inc · Inv · Prl · Pet · Pzn · Prn · Rst · Stn · Uns · Conc

Triggers & Countdowns

- **End of Round 3** — Lorindar Fey-Steps onto Erith, stag bolts 60 ft into the Living Wood. Sprites peel off. **Combat ends.**
- **Lorindar bloodied (≤42 HP)** — exit on his next turn regardless of round. Fey Step + stag-bolt, ignore recharge.
- **Erith reduced to 0 HP** — Lorindar dismounts on his next bonus action, Scripted Exit comes forward one round.
- **Sela steps between** — Sela calls Lorindar's name aloud, walks the firebreak. PCs hold. Lorindar bows, departs. Standard delivery: ✓. *Best Sela outcome.*
- **Party holds weapons through the entire speech** — initiative never rolls. Lorindar bows, departs. *Vanishingly rare — mark it big.*
- **Avoid: Lorindar dies.** Worse problem afterward (new fey lord with a personal grievance). Sela goes white. Audience invitation rescinded. Move it to an S6+ war. Let it cost.
- **Avoid: a PC dies.** Use Sela's intervention to bail if a kid drops to 0.

Tactics Summary

- **Lorindar** — R1 speak the audience invitation (Standard-Bearer's Word, free), move Erith to ~30 ft of the PC who drew first, glaive ×2. R2 continue, Reproof the second hit. R3 Fey-Step + stag-bolt escape.
- **Sprite Outrider 1 & 2** — R1 Heart-Sight Arrows at the two PCs who drew first; any sprite reading "fear, not malice" **holds fire** the rest of the fight. R2 Sleep-Tipped Arrows at the loudest-output PC (non-lethal). R3 cover the Herald's exit, peel off.
- **Civilian screen (DM-controlled, won't act unless asked):** *Captain Helm* holds the militia line; will body-block a sprite-shot for a civilian; **will not** attack Lorindar (he feels the standard). 4× *Shadowdale reservists* behind Helm, spear-and-shield, won't engage without orders. *Rellan Tessar* at the riverbank with his bow — rushes in only if Kto is downed (story beat, not damage). *Sela Wyndmere* at the treeline; **will not attack either side** — she is the trigger and the brake.

Loot / Aftermath

- No coin, no gear (Lorindar escapes). If bloodied and Reproof misses, the standard's iron-antler tip falls — **cold-iron token, fey-court provenance**, worth a favor not a sale.
- If Erith is killed: a white antler is shed on the river-stones. Sela trigger.
- If a sprite is killed: the other sprite breaks off immediately, follows the Herald. Don't kill both unless the party is going *very hard*.

Lorindar Greenmantle, the Antlered Herald

Tall, slender fey, green-skinned and antler-crowned. He rides a stag the size of a draft horse. He bears the standard of the Bright Court Beneath — a white branch crowned in iron antler, hung with three ribbons of green, white, and bone. His voice is courteous. He has not raised it once. He is also visibly armed — a long fey-iron glaive across his saddle.

Fey, Chaotic Neutral • CR 5 (1,800 XP)

AC	16 (woven leaf-mail)
HP	85 (10d8 + 40) • Bloodied 42
Speed	30 ft. (40 ft. mounted on Erith)
STR	14 (+2)
DEX	18 (+4)
CON	18 (+4)
INT	15 (+2)
WIS	17 (+3)
CHA	18 (+4)
Saves	DEX +7, WIS +6, CHA +7
Skills	Insight +6, Perception +6, Persuasion +7, Stealth +7
Damage Resistances	Bludgeoning, piercing, slashing from nonmagical weapons not made of cold iron
Condition Immunities	Charmed, frightened
Senses	Darkvision 120 ft., passive Perception 16
Languages	Common, Elvish, Sylvan

Features. *Magic Resistance:* advantage on saves against spells and magical effects. *Fey Step (recharge 4–6):* bonus action, teleport 30 ft. (treat as at-will on the Scripted Exit). *Standard-Bearer's Word:* once per encounter, as a free action on his turn, Lorindar speaks one sentence audible to all creatures within 60 ft. through any obscurement or silence — **the audience invitation gets delivered no matter what**. *Mounted Combatant (Erith):* opportunity attacks against Lorindar have disadvantage while mounted.

Actions. *Multiattack:* two Antler-Crown Glaive attacks. *Antler-Crown Glaive:* melee, reach 10 ft., +7 to hit, **1d10 + 4 slashing + 1d8 force** (~14 avg). *Bow of First Light:* ranged 150/600, +7 to hit, **1d8 + 4 piercing + 1d6 radiant** (~12 avg). Bow used **only at range** and only against an armored target (Kto). He is not aiming to kill.

Bonus Actions. *Fey Step* (see Features). *Standard's Bearing:* raise the standard — until start of his next turn, allies within 30 ft. (the sprites) gain advantage on saves vs frightened or charmed.

Reactions. *Reproof of the Court:* when a creature within 30 ft. hits Lorindar with a melee attack, impose **disadvantage** on that roll — once per round only.

Round-by-Round Tactics.

Round 1. Free action: *Standard-Bearer's Word* — speak the audience invitation. Move Erith to within ~30 ft of the PC who drew first. Glaive ×2 against that PC. Making a point, not a corpse.

Round 2. Continue glaive on the same target. *Reproof of the Court* on the second hit if available.

Round 3. Scripted Exit. *Fey Step* onto Erith's back if dismounted (treat as at-will, ignore recharge). Stag bolts 60 ft. into the Living Wood. Sprites peel off. Combat ends.

If bloodied earlier than R3: exit immediately on his next turn — *Fey Step* + stag-bolt regardless of position.

On defeat. Bad outcome. New fey lord with a personal grievance afterward. Sela goes white. Audience invitation rescinded. Move to an S6+ war. Let it cost.

Erith-of-the-First-Snow (*stag mount* — *not a separate combatant*)

Riding-horse stats with *Pass Without Trace* active on Lorindar. **AC 12 • HP 30 • Speed 60 ft.** Attacks abstracted into Lorindar's. If reduced to 0 HP → Lorindar dismounts on his next bonus action, Scripted Exit comes forward one round.

Sprite Outrider (×2)

Small fey, two of them, mounted on fey-touched giant owls — pale gray feathers and starlight in the pupils. The sprites carry tiny longbows that read as toys until you watch them shoot.

Fey, Chaotic Neutral • CR 1 (200 XP each)

AC	15 (leather + fey grace)
HP	22 (5d6 + 5)
Speed	10 ft. ground, 60 ft. fly (80 ft. on owl mount)
STR	8 (−1)
DEX	18 (+4)
CON	12 (+1)
INT	14 (+2)
WIS	14 (+2)
CHA	13 (+1)
Skills	Perception +4, Stealth +6
Senses	Darkvision 60 ft., passive Perception 14
Languages	Common, Elvish, Sylvan

Features. *Mounted (Giant Owl):* the owl provides a flying mount; the sprite uses the owl's movement. *Heart-Sight:* as an action, touch a creature OR succeed on a DC 13 ranged shot with a *Heart-Sight Arrow* to read its surface emotional state. If a sprite reads "fear and confusion, not malice" on a PC, that sprite **holds fire** and will not attack lethally next round.

Actions. *Shortbow:* ranged 40/160, +6 to hit, **1d6 + 4 piercing**. *Sleep-Tipped Arrow* (1/encounter each): ranged 40/160, +6 to hit, **1d6 + 4 piercing**; target makes a **CON DC 12** save or is **incapacitated (drowsy) until end of its next turn**. Non-lethal. Used against the most dangerous-looking PC in R2. *Heart-Sight Arrow* (1/encounter each): ranged touch 40/160, DC 13 vs AC, 1 piercing on hit (a "tap"), reads target's surface intent.

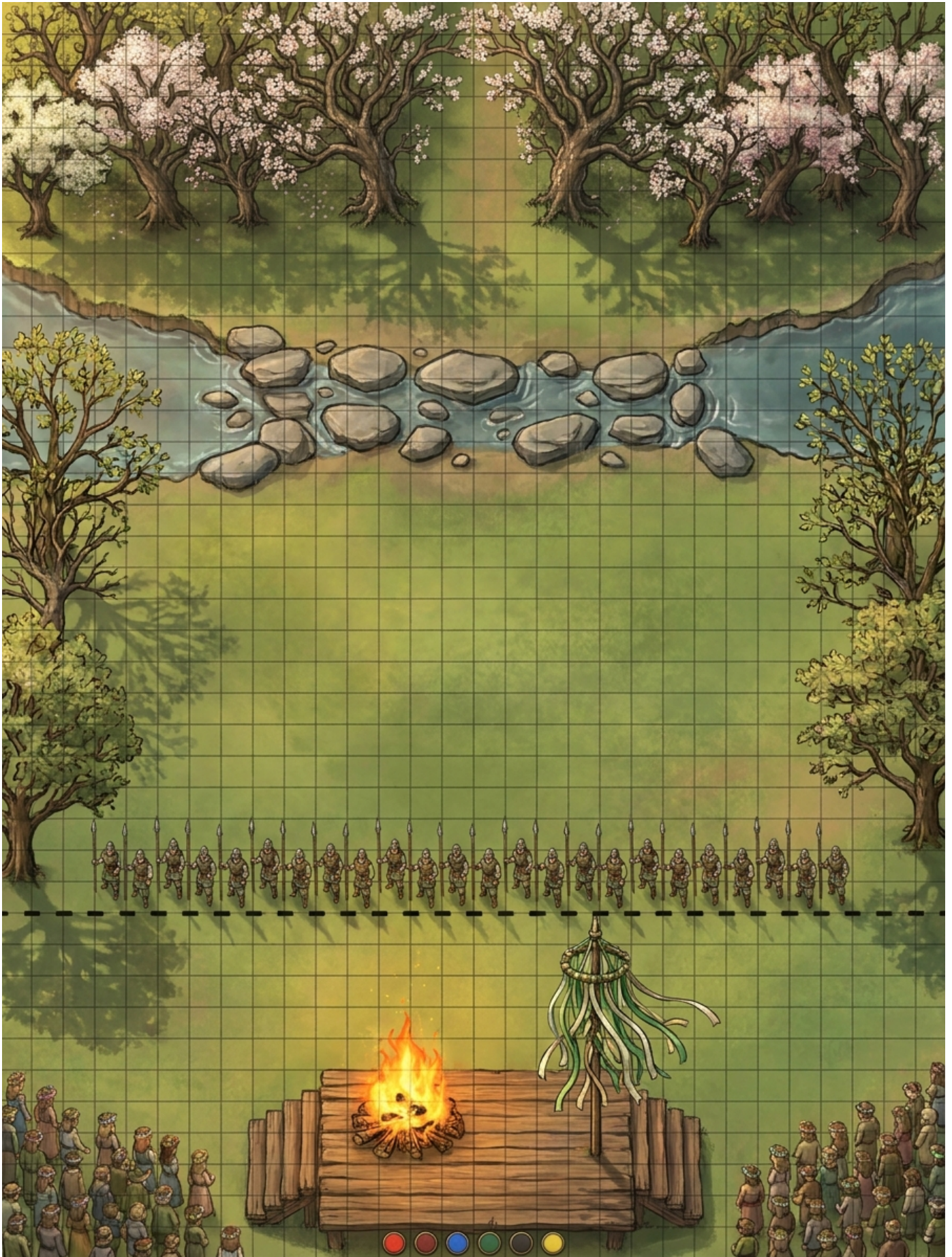
Round-by-Round Tactics.

Round 1. Hover 80 ft up. Heart-Sight Arrows at the two PCs who drew first. Any sprite reading "fear" holds fire the rest of the encounter. If both read "rage," continue.

Round 2. Sleep-Tipped Arrows at the loudest-output PC (Yinu or Fiorn). Aim is to drop the PC on the firebreak, not kill.

Round 3. Cover the Herald's escape with regular shortbow fire. Peel off into the Living Wood as the stag bolts.

On defeat. A sprite dropped to 0 HP → the other sprite breaks off immediately and follows the Herald. Don't kill both unless the party is going *very* hard.



Where We Left Off



You are standing over Khelziir Aun'velve's body in the Shrine. The drow priest is dead — Sev's Scorching Ray took him while Piper held him with *Hold Person*. Caitlin took down Zeldrazz T'orrl with her greatsword in the same round; the man who came back to finish her got finished instead. The portal anchor is still humming on the basalt altar, half-finished. *It is waiting for someone to finish.*

The Lolthites never came. The fight ended before the ritual hit zero. Both surface drow are dead. **Site C is closed.**

Nema is at the cleft mouth on overwatch and steps in as the dust settles. **Loric isn't on the trail with you today — he stayed back at the Old Skull.** You're four for the walk home.

What Now?

- **The anchor.** Smash it, take it, leave it running with a Harper listening glyph slipped in — or walk away. Yinu's Arcana can read enough of the inner ring to know there is something **fey** built into the heart of it that the drow never noticed.
- **The walk back.** Half a day overland down the southern face of the Old Skull, then home.
- **Brynn Ashford's letter** is still in Kto's belt-pouch. The party still doesn't know it exists — unless someone tells them.
- **The Ashaba House is waiting.** Lady Ulphor is hosting Greengrass tomorrow. She has not yet asked you to stay. She will.

The Greengrass Festival



Greengrass is the first night of Mirtul — the cusp between winter and spring on the Dalelands calendar. Flowers, peace, and the first open river-crossings of the year. The Living Wood's druids walk the Greening at the wood's edge. The village green is bonfired. Old grudges are set aside for one night. The fey, by old tradition, walk the surface openly.

Shadowdale's festival is small but stubbornly proud — flower crowns on every fence, a procession from the Twilight Tower to the river-stones, an evening bonfire that Lady Ulphor lights herself, and four stations on the green that the kids of Shadowdale have been training all winter to win.

The Ashaba House is your bed and your beer for the next twenty-four hours. *"You will not be charged for the Ashaba House while you are mine."*

The Stations

- **The Riverbank Archery Range** — floral-bobber targets in the Ashaba current. **Captain Helm** judges. **Rellan Tessar** is shooting in the same heat.
- **The Bardic Showcase** — under the Twilight Tower banner. The headliner is **Halbren Vass**, a touring half-elf with too much pomade.
- **Orvyn Tal's "Wonders of Spring" Arcane Stall** — three mystery items donated by villagers, identified live for the crowd. **Orvyn** quietly judging.
- **The Dragonchess Open** — back room of the Old Skull Inn. **Brynn Ashford** running the bracket and playing in it.
- **The Greening of the Beasts** — at the Living Wood's edge. **Sela Wyndmere** assisting. Flowers, blessings, a skittish doe.

*(If your sheet is still settling, the **Festival Footrace** along the south bank of the Ashaba is the floor option.)*

Lady Ulphor — Keeper of the Pendant of Ashaba



The Lady of Shadowdale. She has paid Captain Helm's stitches twice now to cover your mistakes, and she has paid you for two closed sites and what looks like a third. She is starting to think of you as **hers**. Tomorrow she will pin ribbons on every one of you. Tomorrow she will light the bonfire with her own hand. Tonight she has invited you to stay.

Brynn Ashford — Shadowdale's Delegate to the Dales Council



Lean, ink-stained, thirty. Speaks for Lady Ulphor at the Dales Council in Ashabenford. **He saw Kto shift the letter in her belt-pouch at the debrief.** He will not ask about it. He pulled her aside in the hall on the way out and said, quietly, only to her:

"I am at the bookshop on Thursday afternoons."

That is the whole conversation.

He is also running the Dragonchess Open tomorrow.

Captain Corwick Helm — Captain of the Shadowdale Militia



You and Helm have been at odds since Session 002, when Fiorn opened a door he was told not to and the rest of the party did the rest. Lady Ulphor paid Helm's stitches and Helm's pride out of her own purse. He has been ordered, by Lady Ulphor, to **judge the archery range** tomorrow as part of the reconciliation she paid for.

He is wearing dress greens with his sword on the wrong hip. He has not said anything to any of you about that.

Orvyn Tal — Shadowdale's Bookseller (And Something Else)



Brynn told Loric in Session 002, quietly, that **Orvyn is a Harper**. Orvyn has never said this. Orvyn has, however, been at every briefing, and has *quietly* paid for Yinu's last two spellbook pages, and has *quietly* asked Lady Ulphor — once — about "the aasimar with the quill." He runs the bookstall at the festival tomorrow.

There is a wrapped book on the bookstall counter. It is not for sale.

Sela Wyndmere — Shadowdale Healer (And Something Else)



The village healer. She is also the only Shadowdaler the fey of the Living Wood will speak with — and lately, she has been carrying messages she doesn't read for a lord she can't name. **She has not told anyone.** She will assist Nalith at the Greening of the Beasts tomorrow afternoon.

She wears a ribbon at her belt — a knot of bone and green stitched in a pattern Sela cannot explain. The fey she carries messages for tied it for her.

Halbren Vass — Touring Bard, Possibly Insufferable



Headlining the Bardic Showcase. He has been at the Old Skull Inn for three days, drinking other people's beer and asking who-runs-what. He has put Fiorn in the closing slot.

He is undefeated on the Dales circuit this year. He will heckle from the wings during your set.

The Bonfire at Dusk



When the sun goes down, the procession reforms on the river-stones. Ribbons get pinned. Lady Ulphor lifts the firebrand. The village holds its breath.

Behind her, at the edge of the Living Wood — a stag steps out of the trees. It is the size of a draft horse. Its antlers are crowned with white blossom. And there is a man riding it.

The Antlered Herald



*"Honored guests of the Lady of the Ashaba — and you five who walked into our borders and walked out again — I am **Lorindar Greenmantle, Herald of the Bright Court Beneath**, and my lord has marked you. He sends greeting on this night of his choosing. He asks..."*

He carries a standard — a white branch crowned in iron antler, hung with three ribbons of green, white, and bone. He is courteous. He has not raised his voice.

He is also visibly armed. A long fey-iron glaive is across his saddle.

If you look at his ribbons — and then at Sela's belt — they are the same knot.

The Sprite Outriders



Two of them. They circle eighty feet up on fey-touched giant owls. Pale gray feathers. Starlight in the pupils. The little bows in their hands look like toys.

They are not toys.

The Audience Invitation

(Lorindar will deliver this aloud once, regardless of whether you let him. It is heard by every PC and by Lady Ulphor.)

My lord of the Bright Court Beneath extends to the five who walked his borders an audience at the next full moon, on neutral ground, the hawthorn-cleft of his choosing. The Lady of the Ashaba is welcome. You are welcome. The fire is welcome.

Come.

DM Quick Reference — The Greengrass Greengage Affair

Session 004 · Print and keep at the table · Full detail in file 1 (adventure) and file 2 (combat)

Scene Order

#	Scene	Key mechanic	DM flag
1	Anchor Decision (in the Shrine)	Choice: Smash / Steal / Feed / Withdraw	Yinu Arcana DC 17 for Feed (expertise)
2	Walk Back	Loot divvy · Brynn's letter · scene setting	Greengrass-eve ridge moment
3	Ashaba House Debrief	Pay 600 gp + bonus · Level 6	Print L6 sheets; warmer tone than S2
4	Opening Procession	Read-aloud, station announcements	Four stations + Nema placeholder (Loric absent)
5	Stations (montage)	3-check skill challenges, DC 13/15/17	Cut between PCs; ~5 min/turn max (4 stations)
6	The Bonfire	Ribbons + Lady Ulphor's toast	False moment of safety
7	The Crash	Antlered Herald + 2× Sprite Outriders	See combat tracker
8	Aftermath	Sela opens up · Brynn/Orvyn beats · Quillip hook	End session on the bonfire lit

Anchor Choice — Pay Table

Choice	Anchor bonus	Side effects
Smash	+100 gp	Loud message; drow know
Steal	+200 gp	Orvyn gets the disc
Feed (<i>Harper</i>)	+300 gp	Yinu Harper marker; future listening payoff
Withdraw	+0	Retaliation clock accelerates

Baseline pay: 600 gp split (150 gp / PC across the 4 present — Loric absent) regardless of anchor choice.

Station Skill Challenge — Universal Ladder

Successes	Result
3 of 3 — Gold	Prize + Heroic Inspiration + personal NPC scene
2 of 3 — Silver	Prize
1 of 3 — Bronze	NPC scene
0 of 3	A line, no penalty

Cash prize per ribbon: Gold 25 gp · Silver 10 gp · Bronze 0 gp (out of Lady Ulphor's purse).

Stations — At-a-Glance

PC	Station	Host	DCs	Special
Kto	Riverbank Archery	Helm + Rellan	AC 13 / WIS 15 / AC 17	Gold = public Helm-rift closure
Fiorn	Bardic Showcase	Halbren Vass (<i>new</i>)	PERF 13 / DECEP 15 / PERF 17	Use Encouraging Song for closer
Yinu	Arcane Stall	Orvyn Tal	ARC 13 / INV 15 / ARC 17	Plants: signal-stone + numbing draught
~~ Loric T. ~~	~~Dragonchess Open~~	—	—	Absent this session. Council intel reroutes — Brynn delivers it directly to Kto at the festival.
Nalith	The Greening	Sela + Quillip (<i>invisible</i>)	HERB 13 / PERF 15 / AH 17	Hawthorn berry plant; drop regardless of ribbon
Nema	Footrace (<i>placeholder</i>)	TBD	DEX 13 / CON 15 / DEX 17	Replace once Lilli files Nema's sheet

The Crash — One-Page Combat

Setup

When: Lady Ulphor raises the firebrand at dusk.

Trigger: A weapon comes out before Lorindar finishes his sentence — Sela's ribbon recognized OR a PC moves first.

Round budget: 3 rounds max. Herald escapes when bloodied OR end of Round 3.

Antagonists

Lorindar Greenmantle, the Antlered Herald (CR 5)

AC 16 · HP 85 (bloodied 42) · Speed 30 (40 mounted on stag)

Glaive: +7, 1d10+4 slash + 1d8 force (~14)

Bow: +7, 1d8+4 pierce + 1d6 radiant (~12), 150/600

Fey Step: 30 ft., bonus, recharge 4–6 (at-will on planned exit)

Reproof of the Court: disadvantage on 1 melee hit/round (reaction)

Standard-Bearer's Word: free, 1/encounter — speak 1 sentence, all hear it within 60 ft.

Sprite Outrider × 2 (CR 1 each)

AC 15 · HP 22 · Speed 80 fly (owl)

Shortbow: +6, 1d6+4 pierce, 40/160

Sleep-Tipped Arrow (1/encounter): CON DC 12 or incapacitated 1 round

Heart-Sight Arrow (1/encounter): reads target intent; if "fear" not "malice," sprite holds fire

Round-by-Round Cheat Sheet

Round	Lorindar	Sprites
1	Speak invitation (free). Mount-charge to ~30 ft. of the first-aggressor PC. 2× glaive.	Heart-Sight on the 2 most aggressive PCs. Hold if "fear."
2	Continue glaive on same target. Reproof the second hit.	Sleep-Tipped Arrow on the loudest caster.
3	Scripted Exit. Fey Step + stag bolt 60 ft. into Living Wood.	Cover fire, then peel off.

Ending The Fight

Outcome	When	Result
Round 3 timer	Always available	Herald escapes; standard delivered
Bloodied	HP ≤ 42	Herald escapes early; same delivery
Sela intervenes	PC about to drop OR fight too lethal	Sela steps in; PCs hold; Herald bows out
Audience accepted	PCs hold weapons through speech	Best outcome; mark for S5+
Lorindar killed	PC kill before Round 3	Bad. Cost the table; war begins

Civilian Screen

Helm + 4 reservists + Rellan + Sela hold the line. **PCs do NOT have to triage civilians.** They are behind the militia.

Audience Invitation (Standard-Bearer's Word — say it aloud!)

"My lord of the Bright Court Beneath extends to the five who walked his borders an audience at the next full moon, on neutral ground, the hawthorn-cleft of his choosing. The Lady of the Ashaba is welcome. You are welcome. The fire is welcome. Come."

This is the line Lorindar **MUST** deliver before he leaves. **Drop it in Round 1 as a free action.** Once said, it is heard by all PCs and Lady Ulphor regardless of noise.

Plants for Later (don't pay off this session)

Plant	Source	Pays off in
Lolthite signal-stone fragment	Yinu Station C	Drow war (S5–6)
Vhaeraunian numbing draught vial	Yinu Station C	Drow war (S5–6)
Dried hawthorn berry	Nalith Station E (Quillip)	Fey audience (S5–6)
Anchor's fey-inscribed inner ring	Scene 1, Nalith's Druidic-sense	Future Sela conversation
Harper primer book	Yinu (Gold C or Feed)	Yinu's Harper recruitment arc
Mistledale Council vote (Brynn intel)	Brynn → Kto direct (<i>Loric absent — rerouted from Station D</i>)	Council arc (S5+)
Halbren's "where are you touring next?"	Fiorn Gold B	Fiorn recurring rival

Loose Ends This Session Closes

- **Helm rift** — publicly closed at Kto's Gold station OR at Helm's solo "I was wrong" beat in aftermath.
- **Brynn's letter** — Brynn knows Kto knows. Brynn surfaces it directly to Kto at the festival (Loric absent — Dragonchess on-ramp shelved until Lily is back).
- **Unnamed fey lord** — named (sort of): **the Bright Court Beneath**. Lord's name still withheld for future reveal.
- **Sela's "consultations"** — Sela tells the party, plainly, in the aftermath.
- **Quillip's S3 silence about Sela's lord** — explained on stage.

Loose Ends This Session Opens

- **Audience at the next full moon, hawthorn-cleft**. Mark for S5 or S6.
- **Yinu + Harpers**. Orvyn has tipped his hand.
- **Sela's arc** — she's now actively asking for help. Update factions.md §8.
- **Halbren Vass** — recurring rival for Fiorn.
- **The signal-stone / numbing draught** — Vhaeraunian retaliation clock is *audibly* ticking.

NPCs Onstage (quick refs)

NPC	Role today	Read-aloud anchor
Lady Addee Ulphor	Hosts festival, lights bonfire, "you will not be charged"	Warm, almost maternal
Brynn Ashford	Open dragonchess at the Old Skull (no PC station); pulls Kto aside about the letter + drops Council intel	Sharper; he's a Harper-adjacent operator
Orvyn Tal	Hosts Yinu's stall; Harper recruitment	Quiet, generous, watchful
Captain Corwick Helm	Judges Kto's archery; Helm-rift closure	"I was glad I was wrong about him."
Rellan Tessar	Shoots with Kto; friend-ladder beat	Quietly cheerful, on his feet again
Sela Wyndmere	Greening with Nalith; Crash trigger ; aftermath confession	Knew the standard. Will not lift a weapon.
Halbren Vass (<i>new</i>)	Fiorn's heat; recurring rival seed	Smug, charming, professionally jealous
Quillip Burr-and-Whistle	Invisible at Nalith's station; drops hawthorn berry; aftermath wink	Hint of warning; chained Plot B hook
Lorindar Greenmantle (<i>new</i>)	The Antlered Herald; CR 5 fey	Courteous to a fault. Will not raise his voice.

Level-Up Reminders (Level 6 takeaways)

PC	Class	Level 6 marquee
Kto	Fighter (Champion)	ASI/Feat (suggest Resilient: WIS or Sharpshooter)
Fiorn	Rogue (Thief)	Subclass feature usage (Fast Hands is already humming) — pick up an Expertise option if available
Yinu	Wizard (Order of Scribes)	3rd-level spell slot expansion + scribe feature
~~ Loric T. ~~	~~Sorcerer (Draconic)~~	Absent this session — defer level-up until Lily is back.
Nalith	Druid (Circle of Dreams)	Hidden Paths (Circle of Dreams 6th-level feature — short-rest teleport, very fey-themed; thematic for tonight!)
Nema	TBD	TBD

Timing Budget

Block	Target	Slip-tolerance
Cleaning Up (Scenes 1–3)	45–60 min	Move on at 75 if needed; trim debrief
Procession (Scene 4)	10 min	—
Stations (Scene 5)	60–75 min	Cap at 85; cut if stations drag (<i>4 stations with Loric absent</i>)
Bonfire (Scene 6)	10 min	—
The Crash (Scene 7)	30–40 min	Hard stop at 45. End on Sela if it's running long.
Aftermath (Scene 8)	15 min	—
Total	3:00–3:45	Have a 15-minute break between Scene 5 and Scene 6

DM Don'ts

- **Don't** kill Lorindar. (See file 2 — let it cost if it happens.)
- **Don't** put a civilian in danger. Helm screens. The kids do not have to triage.
- **Don't** force the letter or the Harpers. If kids walk past them, that's fine; both threads survive to next session.
- **Don't** lock Nema's station until her sheet is in.
- **Don't** explain the signal-stone or numbing draught. **Plant** them.
- **Don't** narrate Quillip dropping the berry — *let Nalith notice it.*